

The Noble Dhāraṇī called the Heart of the Buddhas

Ārya-buddha-hṛdaya-nāma-dhāraṇī · Toh 855 · Derge Kangyur

འཕགས་པ་སངས་རྒྱལ་གྱི་ཉི་ཤེས་བརྒྱའ་གི་བརྒྱུད་སྒྲུབ།

The Noble Dhāraṇī Called the Heart of the Buddhas (Sanskrit:

Ārya-buddha-hṛdaya-nāma-dhāraṇī; Tibetan: Phags pa sangs rgyas kyi snying po zhes bya ba'i gzungs) is a short scriptural text of the dhāraṇī type, a form of protective or mnemonic formula that a buddha teaches for the benefit of beings. In the opening of this work, the Buddha is shown residing in a grove beside the ocean in the realm of the buddhas, seated on a lion throne and surrounded by gods, and he addresses the sons of the gods of the Pure Abodes, whom he tells that he will teach a Dharma discourse, the dhāraṇī itself, for the sake of the time after the Tathāgata has passed away. The text is Toh 855 in the Kangyur, the Tibetan canon of translated words of the Buddha, where it is classified among the dhāraṇī texts of the Tantra section.

In the language of India: Ārya-buddha-hṛdaya-nāma-dhāraṇī. In the language of Tibet: The Noble Dhāraṇī called the Heart of the Buddhas.

Homage to all buddhas and bodhisattvas.

Thus did I hear at one time. The Blessed One was dwelling in the Joyous Grove beside the ocean, in the realm of the buddhas, seated on a lion throne beneath a tree that fully pervaded the whole place. Surrounded by a retinue of gods, he gazed before him and taught the Dharma.

Then the Blessed One addressed the sons of the gods of the Pure Abodes, led by the Great Sovereign (Maheśvara) and Good Ascetic, saying: Sons of the gods, listen well, attend closely, and keep this in mind, and I will teach it.

For the sake of the time after the Tathāgata has passed away, the Tathāgata teaches a Dharma discourse, the dhāraṇī called the Heart of the Buddhas. It is meant so that the fourfold assembly may be gathered in, may be taken under care, may be wholly taken under care, and may be led to excellence; so that what is endowed with all meanings and all teachings may be brought to completion; and so that those who have properly entered the Great Vehicle may in every respect attain distinction.

This I shall declare. Take it up, and after I have passed completely beyond sorrow, in the later time, teach it to the fourfold assembly who have properly

entered the Great Vehicle. Teach it, recite it, and do not let it be lost. You must declare it with certainty and proclaim it. To those who are in need and to those who are burdened by obscurations, you must guard the words of the Tathāgata, declare them with certainty, and proclaim them.

They replied: Blessed One, we shall do exactly so. We shall act just as the Tathāgata has commanded. We shall bring this command of the Tathāgata to completion with diligence.

The Blessed One said: Sons of the gods, what is that Dharma discourse called the Heart of the Buddhas? It is this:

Tadyathā. Amale, nirmale, sarva-ākāra-artha-pariprāpte.
Asamanta-sarva-kuna-ākāre-tryadhva. Asaṅga-anāvṛte. Samanta. Daśa-diśa.
Paripūrṇa-jñāne. Sarva-asaṅga-darśana-prāpte.
Sarva-dharma-maḥiśata-paripūrṇe. Sarva-ākāra. Asaṅga-samanvite.
Samanta-apratihate-teje-tryadhva-daśasu. Dikṣu-paripra-āpta. Arthe. Śānta.
Praśānta. Upaśānta. Samaśānta. Vimokṣa-anuprāpte.
Supratibuddha-dharma-dhātu. Atyanta-suniḥsṛte. Sarva-ākāra-niḥsaraṇa.
Anavaśeṣa-vārāṅgahe. Vipramukta. Asaṃyoga. Viprayoga. Sthite-dharmate.
Gagana-sama-prakṛti-pariśuddha. Nirmale. Asamanta. Tryadhva-anugata.
Suprāpte-pūrvānta. Aparanta. Madhya-tryadhva-samanta-anuprāpte.
Anapaśeṣa. Parijñā-prahāṇa. Bhavana. Sākṣāt-kriya-parama-bargate.
Yathā-vādi-tathā-kāri. Sarva-ākāra-sampanne. Sarva-ākāra-mahā-maitri.
Mahā-karuṇā. Sarva-ākāra-samasagraha-anuprāpte.

Sons of the gods, this is the Dharma discourse, the dhāraṇī called the Heart of the Buddhas. Among the fourfold assembly who have properly entered the Great Vehicle, whichever son or daughter of good family carries it on the body, or recites it well from memory and holds it, should not give rise to a discouraged mind. For the Tathāgata, just as he truly is, will abide above the crown of their head, within its bounds. Some will certainly see the buddhas. Some will hear them. Some will teach the Dharma. Some will never forget the dhāraṇī. Those still training on the path will have an unbroken continuity of the path and an unbroken teaching of the Dharma, and they will never forget what they have grasped. Their obstacles will be overcome within a single lifetime. Endowed with these qualities, they will attain the dhāraṇī of all the oceans of hearing.

They will attain the forbearance of the nonarising of phenomena, and they will gradually attain the unobstructed liberation of the buddhas, up to its complete

fulfillment. In this very life you should come to fully understand the intention of my teaching. You must also certainly teach and proclaim this to those sons and daughters of good family. Do not let it be lost, do not put it off until later, and do not forget it.

Then they said: Blessed One, we will practice exactly so. Blessed One, in the last times we will teach and explain this Dharma discourse on the dhāraṇī called the Essence of the Buddhas to the four assemblies without postponement and without letting the transmission lapse. We will also certainly teach and proclaim it to those sons and daughters of good family. In this way we will accord with the Tathāgata's word, and we will uphold the sacred Dharma of the Tathāgata. For those sons and daughters of good family, too, this will become a matter of great meaning and great benefit.

The Blessed One declared: Sons of the gods, therefore do just as you have said. This is my instruction to you.

When the Blessed One had spoken thus, the sons of the gods of the Pure Abodes, led by Maheśvara and Tapasvin Bhadra, together with the entire assembly, rejoiced and praised what the Blessed One had said.

This completes the noble dhāraṇī called the Essence of the Buddhas.

The Indian preceptors Jinamitra and Dānaśīla, together with the great editor-translator, the venerable Yeshe De, translated and revised this text. It was later corrected in accordance with the new terminology and finalized.

Translator's Notes

- The mantra is given in the Tibetan transliteration with some evident corruptions (for example "kuna," "mabiśata," "bargate," "paripra-āpta"). I have rendered it in a plain, regularized Sanskrit form without attempting full emendation; its meaning is not translated, as is customary for dhāraṇīs.

The Tibetan "dbang phyug chen po" is rendered "the Great Sovereign (Maheśvara)," a title of Śiva, here appearing as a god of the Pure Abodes; the name that follows, Good Ascetic (dka' thub bzang po), is taken as a separate figure. Tibetan "gnas gtsang ma" is the Pure Abodes (Śuddhāvāsa).

In the final sentence, "skye ba gcig gis thogs pa grub par 'gyur" is obscure; I have followed the sense of obstacles being resolved or overcome within one lifetime, but the wording of the original is somewhat unclear.

- The Tibetan opens mid-sentence, continuing the previous passage's list of benefits. The identification of the speakers in "Then they said" is not given in this passage; presumably they are the sons of the gods addressed by the Buddha just after. The names Maheśvara (महेश्वर) and Tapasvin Bhadra (तपस्विन भद्र), a reconstruction) are

reconstructed from the Tibetan epithets. Maheśvara here is a divine being of the Pure Abodes, not necessarily the Great God Śiva of the epithet usage. The colophon's reference to new terminology refers to the early ninth-century revision of the Tibetan translation lexicon.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.